

Chapter 35: The Weight of What's Unsaid

Jenny noticed it before she understood it.

Austin was the same.

But the space between them wasn't.

It had changed shape overnight.

Not smaller.

Not larger.

Just... heavier.

He arrived earlier again.

Same seat.

Same routine.

Same calm expression.

But Jenny didn't greet him immediately this time.

She didn't mean to delay it.

It just happened.

Like her body had paused before her mind decided to act.

"Morning," she said finally.

Austin looked up.

"Morning."

A pause.

Then—

"You're quiet today."

Jenny shrugged.

"I'm working."

"You said that yesterday."

She frowned slightly.

"...And?"

"I'm observing a pattern."

That word again.

Observing.

Jenny sighed.

"You and your patterns."

Austin didn't react defensively.

He rarely did now.

Instead, he just said,

"It usually means something is changing."

That made her pause for half a second.

"...Nothing is changing."

A lie.

Even she felt it land wrong.

Austin didn't respond immediately.

He just watched her.

Not intensely.

Not accusingly.

Just steadily.

And that steadiness was starting to feel unfamiliar.

Halfway through the shift, Jenny caught herself looking at table seven again.

It was empty.

Of course it was.

Austin was right in front of her.

And yet...

something still felt missing.

She hated that thought.

When things slowed, Austin finally spoke again.

"You haven't asked me anything today."

Jenny didn't look up.

"Should I?"

A pause.

Then—

"You usually do."

That made her stop.

Slowly, she turned.

"...I don't 'usually' do anything."

Austin studied her for a moment.

Then said calmly,

"You ask questions when you're trying to understand something."

Jenny crossed her arms.

"I understand enough."

Silence.

That one stretched longer than necessary.

Then Austin said,

"That's not true."

Jenny frowned.

"You don't get to decide what I understand."

"I'm not deciding," he said.

"I'm noticing."

That word again.

Noticing.

Observing.

Patterns.

Jenny exhaled sharply.

"You're being strange today."

"I'm being consistent."

"That's worse."

A faint pause.

Then—

"Something is bothering you," he said.

Jenny immediately shook her head.

"No."

But the speed of her answer betrayed her.

Austin didn't call it out immediately.

He just waited.

And that waiting made it worse.

Finally, Jenny snapped a little.

"What do you want me to say?"

Austin looked at her.

"Nothing you don't want to say."

"That's not true."

"Yes, it is."

A pause.

Then quieter—

"But I think you're stopping yourself anyway."

That landed too close.

Jenny looked away.

Of course she did.

A customer called from another table.

She used it as escape.

Quick.

Efficient.

Safe.

But when she returned, Austin hadn't moved.

He was still there.

Still waiting.

Still present.

And somehow...

that felt more intense than before.

At closing time, the restaurant was almost empty.

Jenny wiped the counter longer than necessary.

Avoiding.

Delaying.

Thinking without wanting to think.

Austin stood near the exit.

Not rushing her.

As always.

Finally, she spoke.

"About yesterday..."

Austin looked at her.

Silence.

He didn't interrupt.

Jenny hesitated.

Then forced it out.

"Victoria."

That name again.

It felt different in her mouth this time.

Less curiosity.

More weight.

Austin didn't react strongly.

But something in his expression shifted slightly.

"Yes."

Jenny continued.

"You said she was your past."

"Yes."

A pause.

Jenny frowned.

"And I'm what?"

The question came out sharper than she intended.

Even she felt it.

Austin didn't answer immediately.

And that silence...

hurt more than she expected.

Jenny tightened her grip on the cloth in her hands.

"I just want to understand where I stand," she said quieter.

That was the truth beneath everything.

Austin stepped closer.

Not invading.

Just reducing distance.

Then he said calmly,

"You're not a comparison."

Jenny frowned.

"That's not an answer."

"It is," he said.

"For me."

A pause.

Then softer—

"You don't exist in the same place she did."

Jenny swallowed.

"That doesn't tell me what place I am in."

Austin looked at her for a long moment.

Then—

"The present."

Silence.

That word should have been comforting.

But it wasn't.

Because "present" didn't feel like certainty.

It felt temporary.

Jenny turned away slightly.

"I don't like vague answers."

"I know," he said.

"I'm not trying to be vague."

A pause.

Then quietly—

"I'm trying not to lose what we have by defining it badly."

That made her still.

For a moment, neither of them spoke.

The restaurant hummed softly in the background.

Empty.

Almost quiet enough to hear thoughts too clearly.

Jenny finally said,

"So you're saying... don't label it?"

Austin didn't hesitate.

"I'm saying I don't want to reduce it."

That word stayed.

Reduce.

Jenny looked at him.

And for the first time in a while...

she didn't immediately look away.

But she still didn't move closer either.

Instead, she said softly,

"I don't know if that makes me feel better or worse."

Austin nodded once.

"I know."

And that was the problem.

He *did* know.

He left shortly after.

Same pattern.

Same rhythm.

But Jenny didn't follow him with her eyes immediately this time.

She stayed still.

Behind the counter.

Listening to the silence he left behind.

And realizing something she didn't want to admit yet:

She was no longer just involved in his presence.

She was starting to need clarity from it.

And that was where things usually began to change.